

The GOP's 2024 coalition is collapsing

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The GOP's 2024 coalition is collapsing. There's no sugarcoating the bad news for Republicans in today's flagship New York Times-Siena College poll, one of the marquee polls of the midterm cycle.

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The macro-political read is negative enough for Republicans: Democrats lead in the generic ballot by nine points, a 10-point shift from 2024. Trump's approval is at 38%, and he is deep underwater on the key issues of the day: 60% of voters disapprove of his handling of the economy; 70% disapprove of his handling of the cost of living, and 66% disapprove of the war in Iran. Even on immigration, Trump's strongest issue in 2024, Democrats lead by seven points.

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The nine-point generic-ballot lead is slightly stronger than polling averages, which have a Democratic lead of between 7 and 8 points, but it's the latest in a series of high-quality polls—from Quinnipiac and Cygnal in particular—that have shown Democratic leads of eight points or more. This will likely lead to polling averages shifting more toward Democrats in the coming days.

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Under the hood, the picture is worse. Trump's 2024 victory was predicated on a new Republican coalition in which younger cohorts and Hispanic voters would play an increasingly large role. Today's poll, though, points to the collapse of that coalition: Hispanic voters and voters aged 18 through 29 both lean toward Democrats by over 35 points this year, a major reversal from under two years ago (see chart below).

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Collapsing support among young and Hispanic voters matters most in Texas, a disproportionately young and Hispanic state, but it reverberates across the board, as it means that Republicans need to run up

their margins among their core base voters instead. With those voters also squeezed on the cost of living—especially gas prices—that isn't an easy task, and it's key to our view that 2026 will be a strongly Democratic-leaning year.

Supreme Court ruling indicates courts will resist any midterm interference. The Supreme Court left in place a lower court's block on the White House's executive order on new mail-in voting regulations, meaning the order will not be in effect for the 2026 midterms.

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This is a notable loss for the administration before the Supreme Court, and the fact that four conservative justices voted to uphold the block while litigation proceeds should be seen as a signal about the court's non-inclination to play ball with any attempts the administration may make to interfere with the conduct of the midterms, before or after election day.

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While Republicans around the country could try to litigate results in close House or Senate elections in November, every indication so far is that the federal court system will move quickly to hinder any such attempts. That means they would function primarily as rhetorical rallying points for Republicans, similar to the litigation over the 2020 result.

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The order on mail-in voting could well reappear for the 2028 election; litigation over the coming months and years will focus largely on the question of whether the US Postal Service has the legal ability to implement such restrictions, and whether such restrictions interfere with states' rights to administer elections. If the courts do allow the order to be implemented eventually, it would likely be with ample preparation time for states, making it far less disruptive than if implemented in the short period before the midterms.

Pentagon report hints at reduced US presence in Middle East after Iran war. The Pentagon Inspector General released an official report to Congress yesterday detailing the costs incurred by the US through Operation Epic Fury—totaling \$33.4 billion as of 29 June—but notably omits estimates of damage to US bases in the Middle East.

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The Pentagon paid for this by reprogramming base budget funds, drawing from money intended for training, maintenance, and rotational force deployments. These drawdowns are likely to continue as the Pentagon faces significant budgetary pressures that are exacerbated by the current continuing resolution, which keeps defense funding flat, and a lack of requested reconciliation funding. That will eventually lead to basic service reductions if new funding doesn't come through.

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The report justifies excluding base damage estimates—which other sources place between \$15-30 billion—by citing the Pentagon's indecision about its future regional presence, indicating that future changes are possible. These potential changes, including choosing to not reconstruct bases due to prohibitive costs or moving positions westward, out of range of regional threats, will be a major component of any posture review that could be ordered by Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth.

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Any redeployment would fall short of a sea change, though. The war with Iran has proved to the U.S. that some bases meant to serve as logistics hubs in conflict—notably the 5th fleet headquarters in Bahrain—are too exposed to attacks, and the U.S. will seek to move troops to more protected areas

rather than withdrawing from the region entirely.

Quote of the Day

"These are not the people I interviewed to serve on the United States Supreme Court, they are merely a shell of their original selves, a Court that is costing the United States Trillions of Dollars with shockingly bad rulings that are of such magnitude that it won't be easily possible for our Country to recover or heal. It is a Court that will go down as having rendered some of the most destructive, hurtful, and damaging decisions in our Country's history." - President Donald Trump's social media statement after the Supreme Court's ruling on mail-in ballots; all of Trump's Supreme Court appointees sided against him, though Justice Brett Kavanaugh was open to switching his position if the case was brought with more time for potential implementation.

On the Radar

17 September: Last day House is in session before midterms

18-28 September: High-Level Week at UN General Assembly

24 September: Trump-Xi summit

2 October: Last day Senate is in session before midterms

3 November: National midterm elections

10 November: US-China tariff truce expires

18-19 November: APEC leaders meeting in China

11 December: Government funding runs out

14-15 December: G20 summit in Florida

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